Payment Provider Comparison: Flutterwave vs Paystack vs Unified Payments

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Recommendation

Go with Paystack as GeoTravel's main gateway. Its local card fee is capped at ₦2,000 per transaction, and flight tickets and packages are high-value payments. On a ₦2,000,000 booking, Paystack charges at most ₦2,000. Flutterwave's reported 2.0% would be ₦40,000 unless it confirms a similar cap.

Add Flutterwave only if foreign-currency customers are a large share of sales. Its multi-currency collection (NGN, USD, GBP, EUR) suits diaspora travellers and USD costs. Running two gateways doubles the reconciliation work, so start with one.

Keep Unified Payments as a negotiation option for later. It is bank-owned infrastructure with direct Visa, Mastercard, Amex and UnionPay acquiring. Its rates aren't published and onboarding is through a sales process. That suits a high, steady volume more than a website still scaling.

This compares Paystack, on the assumption that "payment" in the brief meant Paystack.

Side-by-side comparison

Paystack's fees come from its own pricing page. Flutterwave's are from 2026 industry comparisons, which report them inconsistently. Unified Payments publishes no merchant rates.

	Paystack	Flutterwave	Unified Payments (UP)
What it is	Online payment gateway (owned by Stripe)	Online payment gateway, pan-African	Bank-owned payments company (founded 1997); card acquirer and terminal aggregator (PTSA) licensed by the CBN

	Paystack	Flutterwave	Unified Payments (UP)
Local card fee	1.5% + ₦100, capped at ₦2,000; ₦100 waived under ₦2,500	Reported 2.0% (raised from 1.4% in April 2025); cap unclear	Not published; negotiated
International card fee	3.9% + ₦100; Amex 4.5%	Reported 3.8–4.8%	Not published; direct Visa, Mastercard, Amex, UnionPay acquirer
Payment methods	Cards, bank transfer, USSD, QR, Apple Pay, direct debit	Cards, bank transfer, USSD, mobile money, OPay, eNaira, AfriGo	Cards; PayAttitude (phone-number payments)
Currencies	NGN, USD	NGN, USD, GBP, EUR	Confirm with UP
Settlement	Next business day (T+1)	T+1; instant settlement for a fee	Confirm with UP
Payouts / transfers	₦10–50 per transfer	Reported ₦10–45 per transfer	Confirm with UP
Setup	Self-serve sign-up, test environment, ready-made checkout; days to integrate	Self-serve sign-up, test environment, ready-made checkout; days to integrate	Sales-led onboarding; longer integration
Best fit for GeoTravel	High-value naira bookings; predictable costs	Diaspora and foreign-currency customers	High, steady volumes with negotiated rates

Fee on a single local card payment (Paystack pricing page; Flutterwave at the reported 2.0% with no cap):

Booking value	Paystack	Flutterwave
₦50,000	₦850	₦1,000
₦500,000	₦2,000	₦10,000
₦2,000,000	₦2,000	₦40,000

If Flutterwave confirms a ₦2,000 cap, the two cost about the same on large bookings.

What the choice changes

Area	Paystack	Flutterwave	Unified Payments
Customer payments	Strong naira checkout (card, transfer, USSD); fewer foreign currencies	Widest choice of methods and currencies; best for diaspora	Card-focused; fewer modern options such as transfer and USSD checkout
Reconciliation	One daily settlement report; each payment carries GeoTravel's booking reference; real-time payment alerts to the website	Same, but more currencies means more settlement accounts to match	Bank-style settlement files; more manual matching unless we build tools
Refunds & disputes	Refunds through the dashboard or automatically from the website; dispute handling in the dashboard	Same	Handled through UP and the acquiring bank; slower
Cash flow	Money arrives next business day, minus fees	Next business day, or instant for a fee	Depends on the agreement
Splitting revenue with partners	Can split a payment automatically between GeoTravel and partners (eSIM, insurance, transfers)	Also supports split payments	Confirm with UP
Engineering effort	Low: days	Low: days	Higher: weeks, plus sales onboarding

What stays the same, whichever we pick:

- Every booking gets its own reference, sent with the payment, so each settlement line matches one booking.

- Fees are taken before money is settled, so finance records net amounts and books the fee as a cost.
- Cancelled flights need clear refund rules: who pays the gateway fee, and how long refunds take.
- The website will connect to the gateway through one layer, so GeoTravel can add or switch providers later without rebuilding checkout.

Questions to settle before signing

All three

- [ ] What discounted rate applies at GeoTravel's expected monthly volume?
- [ ] What are the chargeback fee and the dispute process for travel bookings?
- [ ] How long do refunds take, and is the original fee returned?
- [ ] Can we collect and settle in USD, to pay airlines and suppliers?
- [ ] What settlement reports and data exports are available for finance?

Flutterwave

- [ ] Is the local card fee capped, and at what amount?
- [ ] What is the exact international card fee?

Unified Payments

- [ ] What is the full price list, including setup and monthly fees?
- [ ] Is there an online checkout with an API, and how long does integration take?
- [ ] Which payment methods and currencies are supported, and how fast is settlement?

Sources

- Paystack: What are Paystack's transaction charges?
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- Kolonell: Paystack vs Flutterwave fees and payouts, Nigeria 2026
- Miden: Top 5 payment gateways in Nigeria (2026)
- Devex: Unified Payment Services Limited
- BusinessDay: Unified Payments gateway licence (May 2024)